

South Carolina - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-25 underlying profile with a legitimate defensive star and established quarterback.
Preseason consensus	AP others receiving votes, 10 votes · SEC media 11th · SP+ No. 24
Returning production	68% (No. 6) overall · Off. 76% (No. 3) · Def. 61% (No. 31)
Primer power rating	+12.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.5 wins · most likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better, but not cleanly
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: QB LaNorris Sellers and OC Kendal Briles must make the offense more sustainable, while DC Clayton White's defense remains the stabilizer around EDGE Dylan Stewart.

Bottom line: South Carolina has top-25 talent signals, but a brutal schedule plus OL/WR attrition make bowl-plus outcomes more realistic than a smooth top-25 season.

Beats expectations if: QB LaNorris Sellers thrives immediately in Briles' offense, OT Jacarrius Peak and the transfer-heavy OL settle into a competent five, and EDGE Dylan Stewart anchors another top-25 defense despite front/secondary losses.

Disappoints if: Protection remains a weekly problem, the post-injury WR hierarchy never replaces enough reliable volume, and the defense is forced to carry too many high-leverage snaps against the SEC-heavy back half.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB LaNorris Sellers returns as the established starter and is the central reason the offense has real rebound upside.
- 2 ★ EDGE Dylan Stewart:** EDGE Dylan Stewart is a national-level defensive centerpiece: AP and Walter Camp first team, preseason first-team All-SEC, Bednarik and Walter Camp Player of the Year recognition.
- 3 Offensive line:** The OL is completely retooled, and two-year starting LT Josiah Thompson is expected to miss essentially the entire season.
- 4 Receiver room:** WR Jayden Sellers and incoming WR Jayden Gibson are both out for 2026, forcing a late reshuffle behind WR Nyck Harbor.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No.13, with a five-game stretch of Tennessee, at Oklahoma, Texas A&M, at Arkansas and Georgia after the bye.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	4-8 (1-7 SEC)	● Poor
Scoring	22.7 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	336.3 YPG	● Poor
Rush offense	111.1 YPG · 3.2 YPC	● Poor
Pass efficiency	7.90 YPA · 13 TD / 11 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	31.9%	● Very poor
Scoring defense	22.1 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	353.0 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	136.7 YPG · 3.8 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	216.3 YPG · 6.96 YPA · 13 TD allowed	● Good / above average

South Carolina's defense was good enough to keep games competitive, especially against the run and by pass efficiency, but an offense that struggled to run and convert third downs gave the team too little margin.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-1.60 · No. 77	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	-0.027 · No. 78	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	37.2% · No. 120	● Poor
Off. explosive-play rate	13.3% · No. 41	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	19.3% · No. 127	● Very poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	+4.46 · No. 27	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.100 · No. 28	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	42.5% · No. 77	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.6% · No. 57	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	15.4% · No. 72	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: South Carolina's defense was genuinely good by opponent-adjusted and EPA measures, while the offense was poor down to down. The 2026 question is whether OC Kendal Briles and QB LaNorris Sellers can keep the big plays while reducing negative snaps behind a rebuilt line.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Shane Beamer - returning	● ↔ Keeps the program leadership and established culture stable entering 2026.
OC / play-caller	◆ Kendal Briles - from TCU OC/QB	● ↑ New structure targets the 2025 offensive weakness; transition risk remains
DC / play-caller	Clayton White - returning	● ↔ Defensive identity and primary caller remain stable

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Christian Clark	Texas	● ↔ Major-role candidate in an explicitly clean-slate RB room.
◆ OT Jacarrius Peak	NC State	● ↔ Expected LT answer, but he still had not advanced to contact work as of Aug. 25 despite continued rehab progress.
◆ WR Nitro Tuggle	Purdue	● ↔ Another major-role contender whose importance increased after two WR season-ending injuries.
◆ IOL Emmanuel Poku	East Carolina	● ↔ Starting-lineup contender in retooled OL.

Out	To	Loss
WR Vandrevius Jacobs	Miami	● ↓ Material 2025 receiver leaves.
OL Trovon Baugh	Texas A&M	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 OL contributor leaves.
OL Nick Sharpe	Michigan State	● ↓ Significant 2025 OL contributor leaves.
OL Boaz Stanley	Purdue	● ↓ Substantial 2025 OL contributor leaves.
OL Cason Henry	Louisville	● ↓ Another meaningful 2025 OL contributor leaves.

Offensive net: ● ↓ High-variance and likely worse in continuity despite portal replenishment; QB stability prevents a more negative overall judgment

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Tomiwa Durojaiye	Illinois	● ↔ Major-role contender in a front replacing professional departures.
◆ DL Kelby Collins	Alabama	● ↔ Another major-role contender in defensive-front competition.
◆ CB Quay'sheed Scott	Kentucky	● ↔ Material secondary addition.

Out	To	Loss
CB Brandon Cisse	NFL (Green Bay), Round 2, No. 52	● ↓ Material 2025 corner leaves via NFL draft path.
DL Nick Barrett	NFL (L.A. Chargers), Round 5, No. 145	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 defensive lineman is an NFL draft loss.
S Jalon Kilgore	NFL (Buffalo), Round 5, No. 167	● ↓ Significant safety leaves via NFL draft path.
EDGE Bryan Thomas Jr.	NFL (Jacksonville Jaguars), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Substantial edge contributor leaves for Jacksonville.
CB Myles Norwood	Louisville	● ↓ Played 10 games/two starts/19 tackles in 2025 and is now at Louisville.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Slightly worse in proven depth, but still anchored by a national star and coordinator continuity

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Briles-led offense centered on QB LaNorris Sellers and WR Nyck Harbor, aiming to turn explosive flashes into sustainable offense.	Established QB, high-end WR and 2025 explosive-play rate No.41.	Protection and chain-moving consistency after extensive OL turnover and August WR injuries.
Defense	Clayton White remains the primary caller, with Torrian Gray expanded in the game plan and EDGE Dylan Stewart as the pressure centerpiece.	2025 opponent-adjusted defense No.27 and EPA/play allowed No.28.	Replacing multiple contributors who moved to professional football while improving average success-rate/explosive prevention.
Special teams	Strong model baseline with returning punter but unsettled placekicker.	SP+ special teams No.19 and Mason Love returns.	Final kicker winner remains open after William Joyce's departure.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↑	High	QB LaNorris Sellers is an established starter and the offense's highest-confidence stabilizer.
RB	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	An open backfield replaces major 2025 production; RB Matt Fuller carries the strongest recognition.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Nyck Harbor anchors the room, but departures and season-ending injuries reduce depth.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium	TE Brady Hunt returns, but major 2025 tight-end contributors departed.
OL	● C	● ↓	Low	The line is heavily retooled, OT Josiah Thompson is expected out and the final five remains unsettled.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	EDGE Dylan Stewart is an elite anchor, but his Aug. 25 rehab had not yet advanced to contact work while multiple professional departures must be replaced.
LB	● B-	● ↔	Medium	Defensive continuity helps, but the unit replaces meaningful production around the returning core.
Secondary	● B	● ↓	Medium	DB Vicari Swain returns, but several NFL/transfer departures force another back-end rebuild.
Special teams	● B+	● ↔	Medium	SP+ rates the unit well and P Mason Love returns, while kicker remains open.
Coaching	● B+	● ↑	Medium-high	Beamer and White preserve program/defensive continuity while Briles adds credible offensive upside.
Overall	● B+	● ↑	Medium-high	Top-25 model quality and strong continuity signals are tempered by OL and receiver availability risk.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Dylan Stewart	EDGE	● National star	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · SEC preseason 1st team · Bednarik · Walter Camp POY	The defense's clearest difference-maker and the player most capable of covering for turnover elsewhere in the front.
LaNorris Sellers	QB	● High-end conference starter / offense ceiling driver	Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Established returning starter is the most important stabilizer for a transitioning offense.
Nyck Harbor	WR	● High-end conference starter	SEC preseason 3rd team	Primary returning weapon becomes even more central after two receiver season-ending injuries.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Vicari Swain	DB	● High-upside returning secondary playmaker	Paul Hornung	One of the more stable returning pieces in a secondary replacing multiple NFL/transfer departures.
Matt Fuller	RB	● Major-role candidate in open competition	Doak Walker	Carries the strongest recognition in a clean-slate backfield with no declared RB1.
◆ Jacarrius Peak (TR: NC State)	OT	● Critical transfer / health return	-	Expected LT answer after Thompson's surgery; he is progressing but had not yet reached contact work as of Aug. 25.
Josiah Thompson	OT	● Key unavailable player	-	Two-year starting LT remains on roster but is expected to miss essentially the entire season, materially weakening continuity.
◆ Nitro Tuggle (TR: Purdue)	WR	● High-importance transfer projection	-	Role significance increased sharply after Jayden Sellers and Jayden Gibson were lost for the season.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Very difficult for a team trying to convert a top-25 power profile into a winning record; early manageable games are followed by a long SEC/Clemson gauntlet.
Difficulty	● 9/10 · Very hard · SP+ SOS No. 13
Hardest stretch	Tennessee -> at Oklahoma -> Texas A&M -> at Arkansas -> Georgia
Swing games	at Florida, Tennessee, at Arkansas, at Clemson
Advantage	Kent State and Towson provide two home games before SEC play, and the Oct. 17 bye separates at Florida from the five-game gauntlet.
Expected	6.5 wins · most likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	5-7 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Likely to attract public respect because of Sellers, Stewart and a top-25 SP+ rating; require the price to reflect the offensive-line and WR attrition rather than the returning-production headline alone.
Back them when	Facing defenses that cannot consistently win up front, especially when Sellers' mobility/explosive creation can offset some of the OL uncertainty.
Fade/pass when	Against elite pass rush/front-seven opponents or when the market treats the 76% offensive returning-production signal as if the OL and receiver availability were unchanged.
Key monitor	Dylan Stewart/Jacarrius Peak return-to-contact timing, final OL five, post-injury WR hierarchy and whether the new Briles offense materially improves early-down success/protection.
Week 1 baseline	vs. Kent State: rating-only fair baseline South Carolina -37.0 ; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: South Carolina -36.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

South Carolina has a stronger foundation than its 4-8 record suggests: QB LaNorris Sellers returns, EDGE Dylan Stewart is a national-level star and the defense remains the steadier side of the ball. The offense, however, is rebuilding around a new coordinator and heavily retooled supporting cast.

A 7-5 rebound is the likeliest outcome because the schedule is among the SEC's hardest. Upside requires competent protection and a healthy WR hierarchy; downside appears quickly if those problems force the defense to carry every close game.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [2025 stats](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [Gamecocks begin spring football drills](#) · [South Carolina promotes Torrian Gray](#) · [Josiah Thompson roster bio](#) · [Beamer says Josiah Thompson most](#) · [Stewart/Peak availability update](#)

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